

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 33 Summary

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In this lesson, we explored the **Spanish gerundio**, which refers to verb forms ending in **-ando** and **-iendo**. These are the Spanish equivalents of English **-ing** forms when used as verbs (like “eating,” “speaking,” “running”). But be careful: **Spanish and English don't use the gerundio in the same way.**

The Gerundio Is Not a Noun

In English, we can use -ing verbs as **nouns**:

- *Running is good for you.*
- *Painting is fun.*

That is called a **gerund** in English grammar.

In Spanish, those noun-like uses are expressed with the **infinitive**, not the gerundio:

- *Correr es bueno para ti.* — Running is good for you.
- *Pintar es divertido.* — Painting is fun.

You would never say *corriendo es bueno* — that would be incorrect. The Spanish gerundio is only used for verbs in action, never as a noun.

How to Form the Gerundio

- **For -ar verbs:** drop the -ar and add **-ando**
hablar → *hablando* (speaking)
trabajar → *trabajando* (working)
- **For -er and -ir verbs:** drop the ending and add **-iendo**
comer → *comiendo* (eating)
vivir → *viviendo* (living)
- **Spelling and stem changes:**
Some verbs undergo spelling changes to preserve pronunciation, especially when the stem ends in a vowel:
leer → *leyendo*

oír → *oyendo*
construir → *construyendo*
Other verbs change their stem:
decir → *diciendo*
dormir → *durmiendo*
morir → *muriendo*
seguir → *siguiendo*

Category 1: ESTAR + Gerundio (Present Progressive)

This is the most common use. It's how you express what someone is doing **right now**.

Formula: **Estar + gerundio**

- *Estoy comiendo.* — I'm eating.
- *Estamos estudiando.* — We're studying.
- *¿Qué estás haciendo?* — What are you doing?

Conjugation of ESTAR in the present:

- yo estoy
- tú estás
- él/ella/usted está
- nosotros estamos
- vosotros estáis (Spain)
- ellos/ustedes están

Imperfect and preterite forms:

- *Estaba leyendo cuando Juan llegó.* — I was reading when Juan arrived. (imperfect background)
 - *Estuvo cocinando toda la tarde.* — She was cooking all afternoon. (preterite, set time)
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Category 2: SEGUIR / CONTINUAR + Gerundio

Used to express “to keep doing something” or “to continue doing something.”

- *Sigo estudiando español.* — I keep studying Spanish.
- *Continúan hablando.* — They continue talking.

Note: *Seguir* is more common, easier to say, and appears more often in conversation.

Category 3: LLEVAR + time + Gerundio

Used to say how long something has been happening (duration).

- *Llevo tres años viviendo aquí.* — I've been living here for three years.
- *Llevamos dos horas esperando.* — We've been waiting for two hours.

Alternative in some areas: *tener* instead of *llevar*

- *Tengo dos años trabajando en esta empresa.* — I've been working at this company for two years.
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Category 4: ACABAR / TERMINAR + Gerundio

Used to say “to end up doing something.”

- *Terminamos comprando la casa roja.* — We ended up buying the red house.
- *Acabó trabajando en la empresa de su padre.* — He ended up working at his father's company.

Usually used in the preterite for completed actions.

Category 5: PASAR(se) + time + Gerundio

Used to say how someone spent their time.

- *Pasé toda la tarde cocinando.* — I spent the whole afternoon cooking.
- *Se pasa el día quejándose.* — He spends the day complaining.

The reflexive form (*pasarse*) is often used when emphasizing how someone fills their time.

Category 6: ANDAR + Gerundio

Means “to go around doing something,” often with a negative or ongoing connotation.

- *Anda buscando problemas.* — He goes around looking for trouble.
- *Siempre anda diciendo mentiras.* — He's always going around telling lies.

Category 7: Gerundio to Express Manner or Method

This answers the question **how** something was done.

- *Corté el pan usando un cuchillo.* — I cut the bread using a knife.
- *Aprendí a nadar observando a los expertos.* — I learned to swim by watching the experts.

Tip: Don't try to translate "by" as *por* in these sentences. Just use the gerundio alone.

Category 8: Verbs of Perception + Gerundio

Use with verbs like *ver* and *oír* to say you saw or heard someone doing something.

- *Vi a María leyendo un libro.* — I saw María reading a book.
- *Oí a los niños cantando.* — I heard the kids singing.
- *Vi a mi jefe comprando flores.* — I saw my boss buying flowers.

Tip: If the person is mentioned, don't forget the **personal "a."**

Category 9: Two Actions at Once (Simultaneity)

Used to say someone was doing one thing **while** doing another.

- *Me desperté pensando en ti.* — I woke up thinking about you.
- *Juan salió gritando.* — Juan left yelling.
- *María entró riéndose.* — María came in laughing.

Often used with verbs of motion like *salir* (to leave), *entrar* (to enter), or *caminar* (to walk).

Important Tip for English Speakers

Spanish speakers use the present progressive **less** than English speakers.

They often just use the **present tense** for things happening now.

- English: *What are you doing?*
- Spanish: *¿Qué haces?* (present tense — this is common and natural)
Not always *¿Qué estás haciendo?*

Use the progressive when you need to emphasize that the action is **in progress right now**, or when the context makes it clear.